



**CITY OF
CAMBRIDGE**



Cambridge Preschool Program Update

City Council & School Committee Roundtable

June 29, 2026

Executive Summary

Context: The Office of Early Childhood (**OEC**) *mission is to strengthen Cambridge's early childhood ecosystem*, ensuring access to high-quality care and education while advocating for young children, their families, and the early childhood workforce

Progress to date: OEC's has *implemented the Cambridge Preschool Program (CPP)*, a program that provides access to free, high-quality preschool for all Cambridge 4-year-olds and priority 3-year-olds

- CPP is the fruition of **Council's long-term commitment**, taking almost a **decade of work** and significant **budget investments**
- Currently in its second year, CPP is serving **858 children** from a diverse mix of background, **40% of whom are priority students**
- The 2026 family survey shows that **families report overwhelmingly positive** preschool experiences across all indicators

Remaining needs: While the CPP program has demonstrated strong early results for target groups, **opportunity remains** with:

- 1) **Income level:** families with incomes 65%+ of AMI are not currently able to access free extended day and summer care [**~110 in group**]
- 2) **Age range:** families with infants and toddlers (below 3) do not receive any childcare support through CPP today [**~1,100 in group**]

Potential paths forward: to **address the gaps in coverage today**, recommend exploring the following **options for CPP ...**

- 1) **Horizontal - extend income limit for families:** extend 3-year-old preschool to all families, extend AMI threshold for coverage
- 2) **Vertical - expand supports for families of infants/toddlers:** identify strategies for offering services and supports, which could include access to free childcare, for lower-income families of infants / toddlers (based on % AMI)

Today: *discussion on how to best prioritize path forward to best meet OEC's mission of strengthening Cambridge's education ecosystem*

Agenda

- **Context - OEC & CPP overview**
- Progress to date - CPP status update
- Remaining needs - Landscape of City's support for ages 0-5
- Path forward - Potential next steps for the program

Updates – Based on the Previous Joint Roundtable Conversation

- Question about the inclusion of faith-affiliated preschools in CPP
- Support for local, community-based preschool providers
- Minimizing “empty seats” within the CPP system, beyond the CPP system
- Ensuring program quality within CPP



CAMBRIDGE
Preschool Program

The background image shows a vibrant preschool classroom. On the left, a brick wall features a window with a colorful paper chain hanging from it. To the right, a wooden shelf holds various toys, including a teddy bear and a green owl. The wall is decorated with children's drawings, a large number line from 0 to 9, and a small sign that says 'AC'.

Context | OEC was created to strengthen the early childhood ecosystem; created CPP to provide free **preschool** for all 4-year-olds and prioritized 3-year-olds



OEC Vision

Every child and family in Cambridge has **access to high quality early care and education** experiences.

As a result, all children **enter school ready to thrive** academically, physically, socially, and emotionally, and **continue to do so** through third grade and beyond.

OEC Mission

To connect the city’s **early childhood ecosystem**, align early childhood services and information, and advocate for and **advance the needs** of all young children, their families, and the early childhood workforce.

OEC’s 4 key areas of work

- 1. **Cambridge Preschool Program (CPP)**
- 2. Program Quality
- 3. Workforce Development
- 4. Family Engagement



Goals of CPP

- 1 Expand preschool **ACCESS**
- 2 Enhance preschool **QUALITY**



Eligibility

- ★ **All 4-year-olds** who are city residents
- ★ **3-year-olds** with **priority status**
- ★ **3-year-olds** with **non-priority status**

Priority status

- Income at or below **65% AMI**
- Eligible for **free / reduced lunch** (for CPS)
- Experiencing **homelessness**
- In **foster care**

Seat matching

- Matching uses **single, online application**
- Families can **rank up to 10** programs
- **Algorithm** matches families

★ **Guaranteed seat** ★ **Eligible for seat**

History | CPP, and OEC more broadly, is the result of many years of work and planning from City Councilors, School Committee members, and other city stakeholders

- “Blue Ribbon Committee” initiated the conversation
- **2015** - The Cambridge Early Childhood Task Force issued recommendations, which included a recommendation to create the “Birth to 3rd Grade (B-3) Partnership” – A city-wide collaborative focused on expanding access to and quality of early childhood programming across Cambridge, especially for lower-income families.
 - Created a scholarship program that provided scholarships to 50 preschool-age children who met income-eligibility criteria. This was later expanded to serve 75 children.
- In **2017** the City Council committed to pursuing universal Pre-Kindergarten. The B-3 Partnership began researching various UPK models.
- In **2019** the B-3 Partnership presented UPK model options to City Council and the School Committee during a Joint Roundtable. Following the Partnership’s recommendation, City Council Committed to following a mixed delivery model. The B-3 Partnership began strategic planning to design this new mixed delivery system.
- The B-3 Partnership became the Office of Early Childhood (OEC) in **2022**. Shortly thereafter, OEC began recruiting CPP program partners, and partnered with a software development firm to design the matching algorithm.
- The CPP system launched in **2024**:
 - Winter 2024 – The first match was implemented.
 - September 2024 – The first group of CPP children started school.
 - October 2024 –The second round of matching was implemented for SY25-26.
 - Early 2025 – Families will be notified of their matches for SY25-26.

Context | The city has a long history of supporting Early Childhood efforts over the years, most recently with the launch of CPP in FY24

Cumulative OEC investment, by year*



City Council commits to universal Pre-K; B–3 Partnership begins researching UPK models

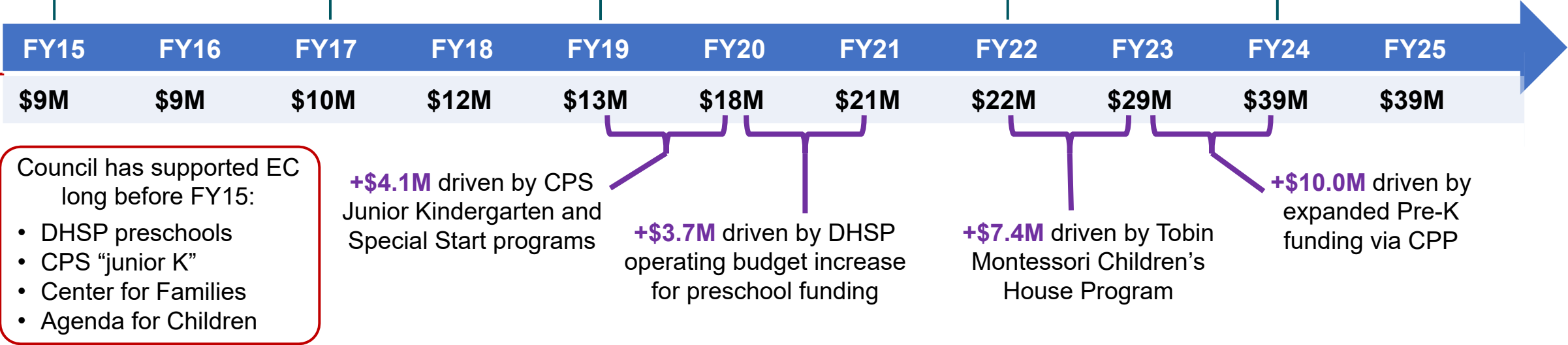
OEC begins recruiting CPP program partners, developing matching algorithm



City launches B–3 Partnership, scholarships for 50 income-eligible preschoolers

B–3 Partnership secures City Council’s commitment to a mixed-delivery UPK model, begins planning new system

CPP launched; first group of children start school in September 2024



*Note: FY19-FY25 Early Childhood Spending pulled from Consolidated Spending in Adopted Budget Books, FY15-FY18 preceded consolidated spending in budget book, DHSP and CPS calculated.

Context | Council’s decision on universal pre-K (UPK) for 4-year-olds aligns with research showing that universal preschool produces better outcomes for children and families

Impact area	Research finding
Academic & Equity Gains <i>(Journal of Human Resources, 2023)</i>	■ Universal pre-K produces significantly larger test-score gains for low-income children than means-tested programs, while middle-income children see similar improvements ■ Universal pre-K includes children typically excluded under means testing and deliver better cost-effectiveness and quality through wider political support and peer classroom diversity
Economic & Workforce Benefits <i>(Yale/National Bureau of Econ. Research, 2024)</i>	■ In New Haven, full-day UPK added ~11 hours/week of care and boosted parent earnings by 21.7%, effects that persisted for at least six years. It delivered \$10 in public benefit per \$1 spent ■ Extended-care UPK improved parents’ employment and earnings especially for middle-income families
Long-Term & Cost-Benefit Insights <i>(various sources)</i>	■ Some academic gains fade by elementary school, but high-quality universal pre-K still improves kindergarten readiness and long-term outcomes <i>(University of Georgia, 2025)</i> ■ Cost-benefit estimates show \$2-4 returned per \$1 spent on quality universal pre-K - driven by improved child and adult outcomes <i>(Journal of Human Resources, 2023)</i> ■ In Georgia, UPK led to higher high school graduation (+1.5pp), college attainment (+1.5pp), reduced SNAP use, lower teen parenthood, indicating lasting societal benefits <i>(Policy Impacts, 2026)</i>

Context | OEC has developed a robust quality monitoring system to ensure that all CPP providers meet the highest quality standards.

Quality Matters

- Research has consistently shown that preschool participation only positively impacts children’s learning and developmental outcomes when the preschool program meets the highest, evidence-based quality standards. Low-quality preschools do not produce positive outcomes for children, and some research even suggests that children who attend low-quality preschools underperform, when compared with their peers, on a variety of outcome measures.

CPP’s Quality Monitoring System

- OEC has implemented a robust quality monitoring system that utilizes a variety of quality measures, all based on research and evidence-based practices, to provide a comprehensive picture of quality across the CPP system and within individual preschool programs.
- The quality monitoring system includes classroom observations, using a nationally normed and validated quality assessment tool, family feedback, and other measures.
 - Teachstone CLASS observations, conducted by external, objective assessors
 - OEC program quality staff observations
 - Family feedback (gathered from surveys, transfer requests, Family Advisory Board)
 - Document review

Stakeholder Engagement

- OEC also works closely with the CPP Program Advisory Board and CPP Family Advisory Board to gather feedback on an ongoing basis and to inform policy and program decisions.

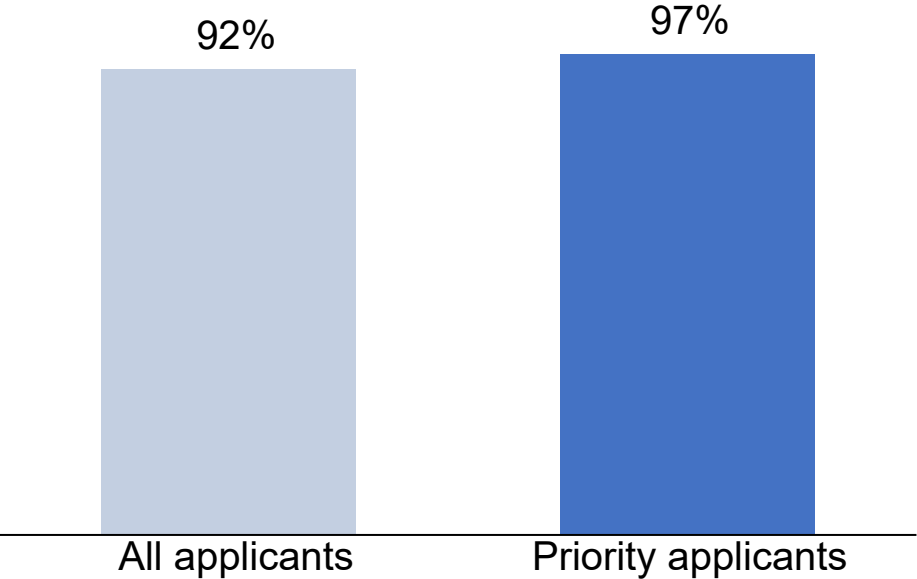
Agenda

- Context - OEC & CPP overview
- **Progress to date - CPP status update**
- Remaining needs - Landscape of City's support for ages 0-5
- Path forward - Potential next steps for the program

Program matching | Vast majority of CPP families are matched with one of their top preschool choices, often based on factors such as location, service hours, & language

Distribution of 553 applicants for the '26-'27 school year

Applicants that received one of their first three choices
In %

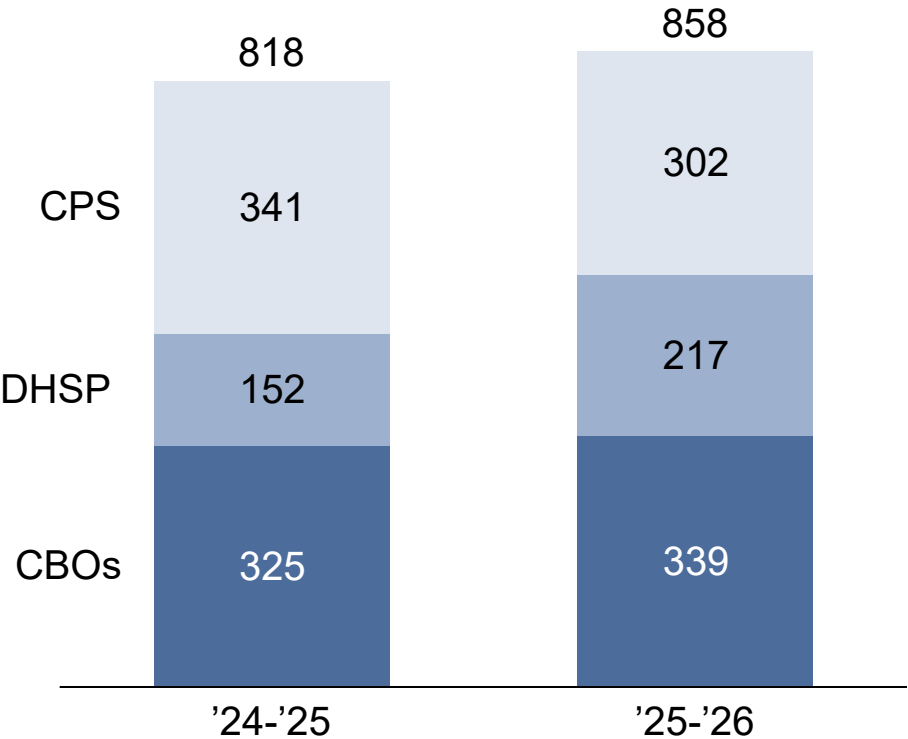


Key factors for families when choosing providers:

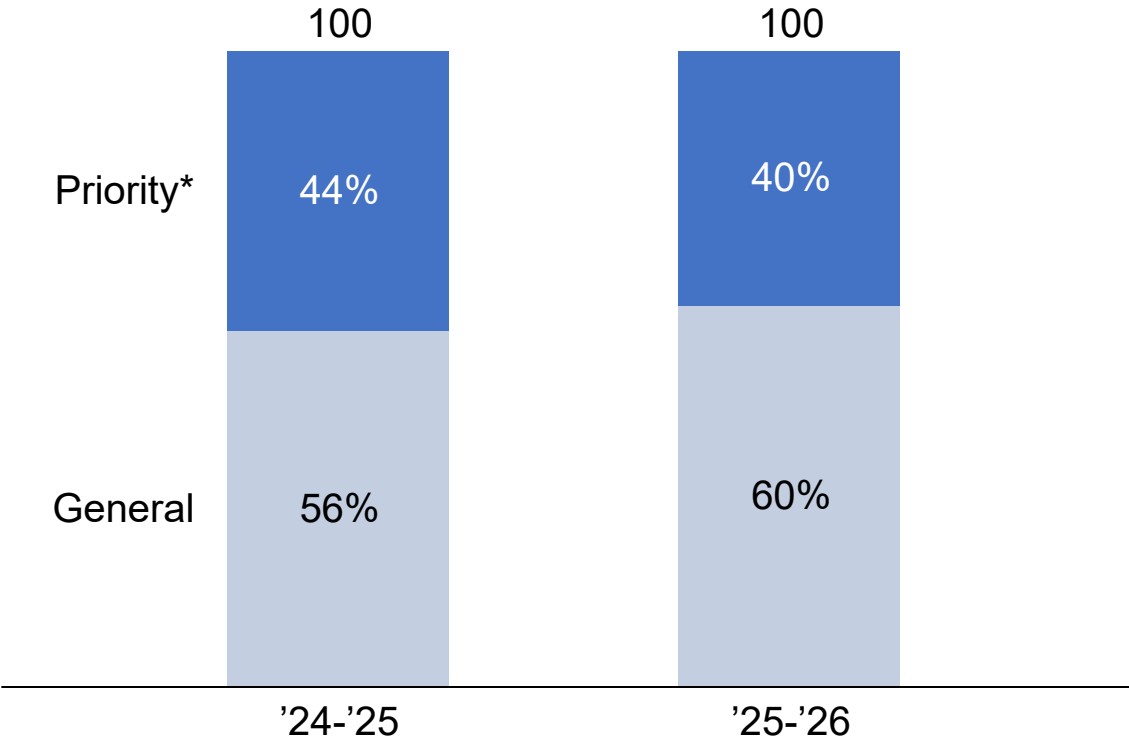
- Location
- Availability of after-school care
- Curriculum
- Language used

Program demographics | Currently in its second year, CPP is serving 858 children, 40% of whom are Priority students

Total CPP students across providers
In number



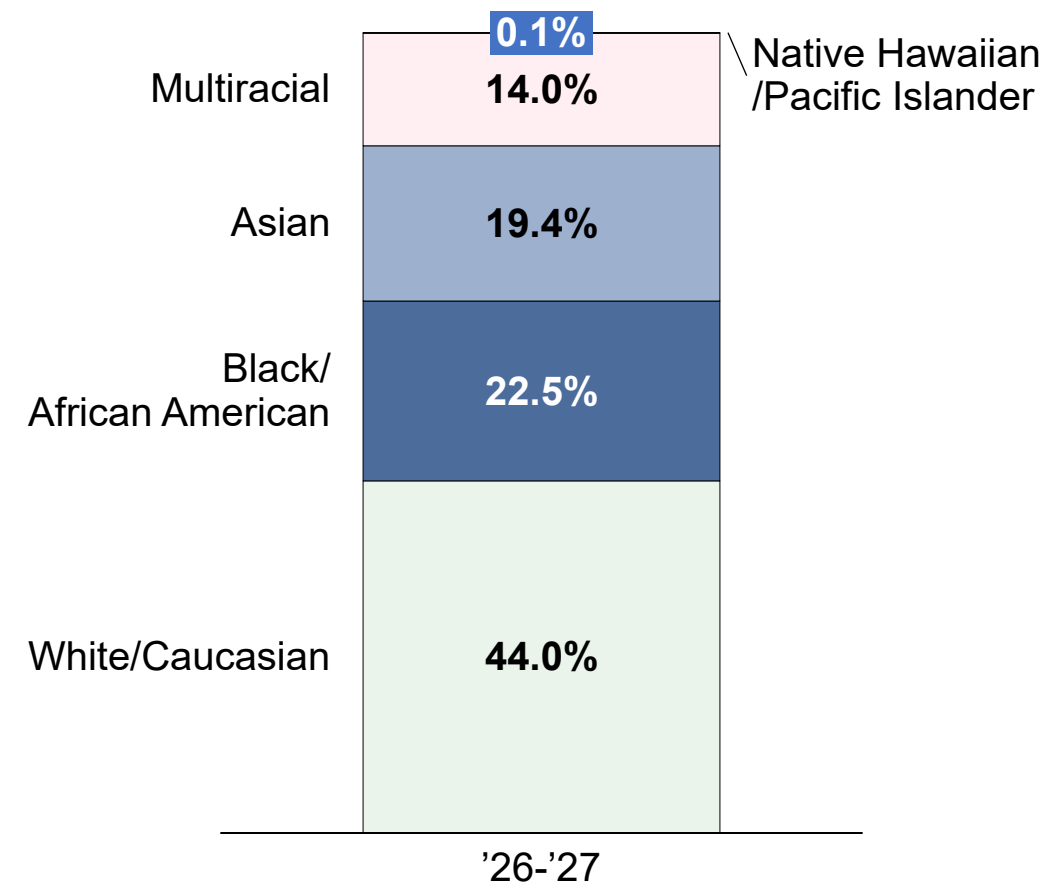
'24-25 to '25-26 enrollees by income group
In %



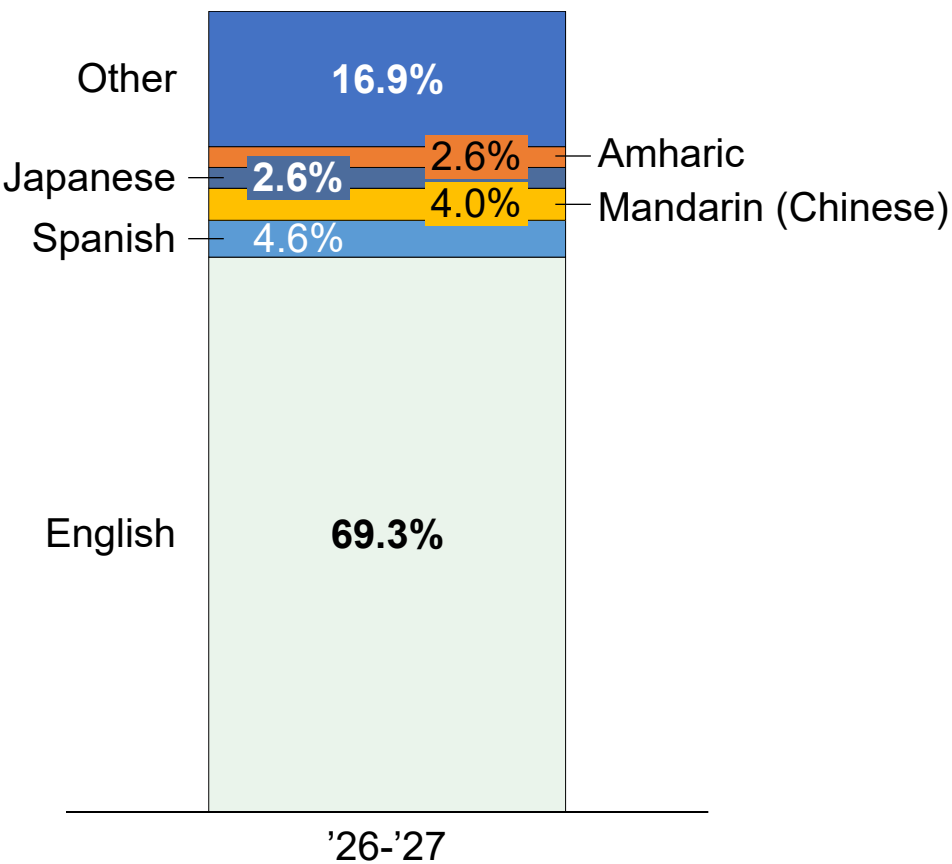
100% of Priority Applicants are served.

Program demographics | CPP students came from a diverse mix of background

'26-'27 enrollees by race
In %

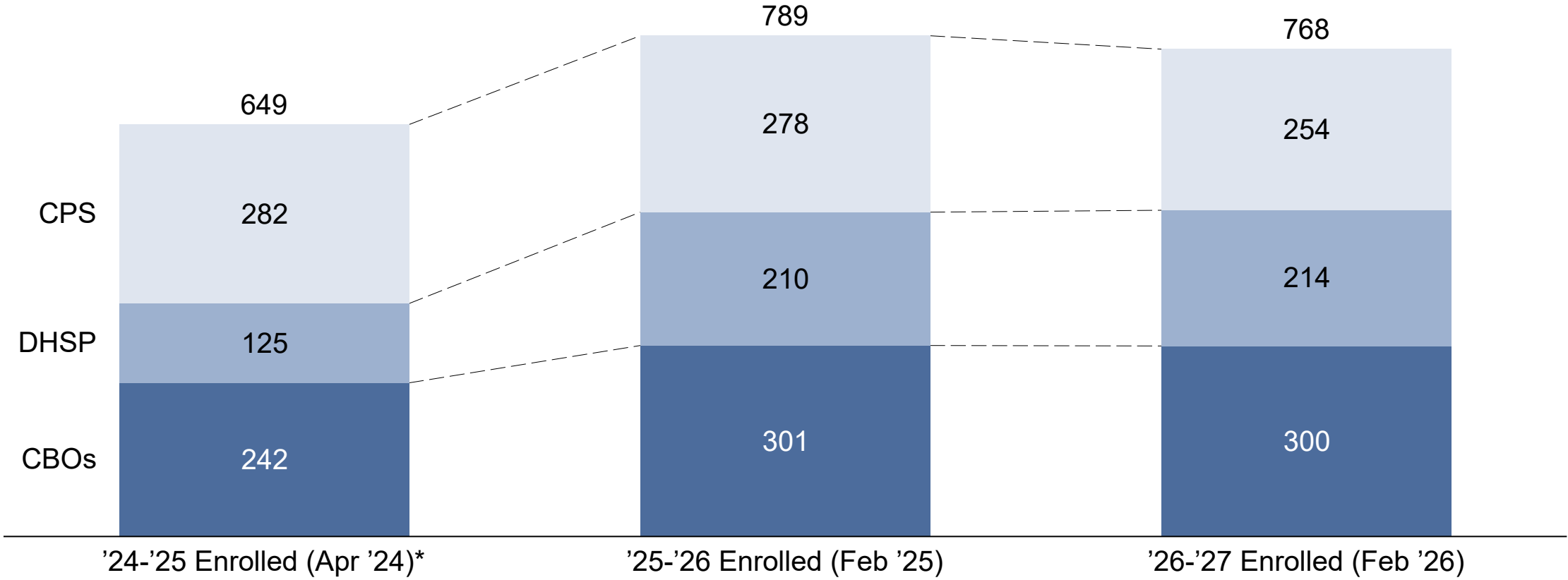


'26-'27 enrollees by language
In %



Program enrollment | Demand for CPP seats has remained relatively stable despite a slight decrease for the '26-'27 school year

Enrolled CPP students at match, '24-'25 to '26-'27
In number

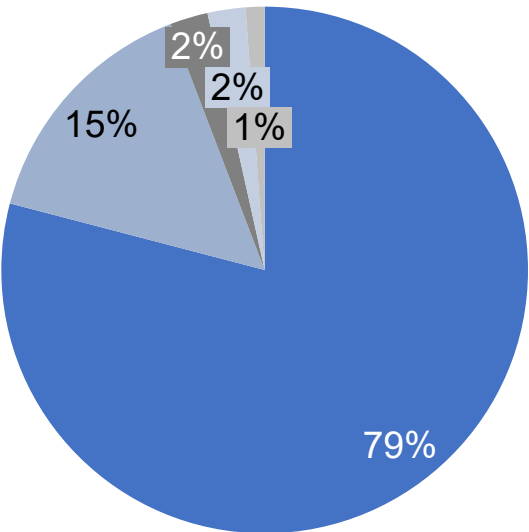


Program feedback | The 2026 family survey shows that families report overwhelmingly positive preschool experiences across all indicators (94% positive; 3% dissatisfied)

Distribution of 172 survey respondents

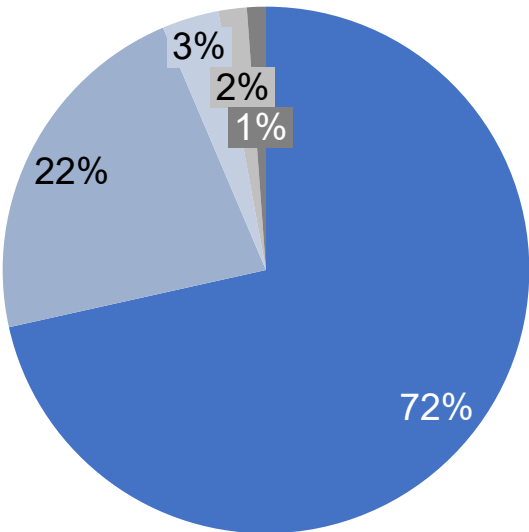
How satisfied are you with your child’s preschool experience?
In %

- Very satisfied
- Satisfied
- Very Unsatisfied
- Neutral
- Unsatisfied



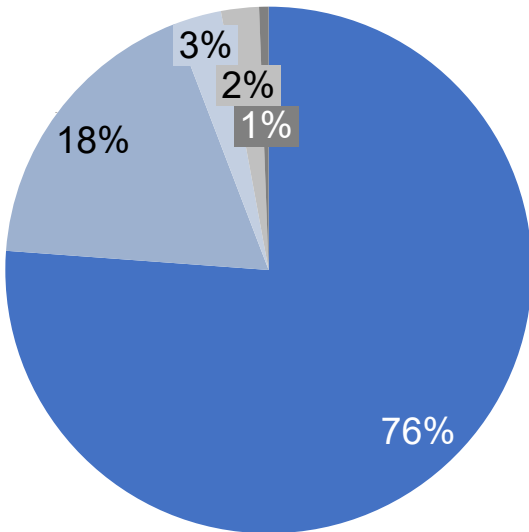
How much does your child like joining in on preschool activities?
In %

- Very excited
- Somewhat excited
- Neutral
- Not excited
- Hesitant



How well does the preschool support your child’s social, emotional, and cognitive development?
In %

- Excellent
- Good
- Fair
- Poor
- Very Poor



Program feedback | The positive experiences are reflected in parents' testimonials, many of which share their gratitude and why they love CPP

We are so grateful for this program!! What an amazing experience for our kiddo and incredible benefit to all Cambridge families. Thank you!!

His growth is evident - at home he is now counting and naming letters and even doing simple math!

We really appreciate you keeping high quality, nonprofit schools as part of CPP and hope that this continues and is prioritized over funding for-profit daycare chains.

I articulated this before, but moving to Cambridge and enrolling our son in Tobin DHSP changed his life, and gave him a childhood where he is flourishing. From the first day, the teachers were so welcoming, supportive, warm and friendly... It has been amazing for us to see him flourish in such a short amount of time, and this is because of the atmosphere that Tobin (and I suspect, CPP) promotes.

Our child loves going to preschool and has not had a single day where she said she does not want to.

As an educator myself, I am really happy with how this program is run and all that my child has learned in Pk3 and Pk4.

Program feedback | Some parents also indicated areas for improvement; lack of summer care / afterschool & confusing differences between programs mentioned most often

The lack of aftercare / holiday / summer care options for 4yos is a major gap in the system. I love that CPP exists but this absolutely has to get addressed for future kids.

We sincerely appreciate the support of CPP. Although it is already huge, it was little difficult to live without summer program around two month.

It was **very confusing choosing between CPS vs DHSP program physically located at a CPS location**, during the PreK lottery process. We... didn't know at the time all the nuances for example that you cannot be on a CPS waitlist if you choose a DHSP school, and how choosing a DHSP program doesn't let your child continue on into Kindergarten at the same school... Parents have to read the rules and process extremely carefully.

The lack of afterschool options for 3-year-olds is **VERY STRESSFUL**... it would have been infinitely more convenient if he could have just attended afterschool at DHSP Tobin. The inconvenience for working families really cannot be overstated and I am hoping something can be done to fix this.

The process of applying through the lottery for pre-K and K was extremely frustrating... **I was regularly told that the problem was that CPP and CPS were different programs and therefore had different rules and process**... The fact that the two programs are not officially connected in terms of policies, problem solving or enrollment was challenging.

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Remaining gaps | CPP has earned strong momentum with currently supported groups; opportunity to expand coverage to other groups in need

		Family income	
		Priority Families (meet income threshold)	General families (do not meet income threshold)
Age	4-year-old	- Free access to preschool - Free access to extended day / summer care	- Free access to preschool - Families pay cost of extended day / summer care (if available at their school)
	3-year-old	- Free access to preschool - Free access to extended day / summer care	LIMITED access to preschool - Families pay cost of extended day / summer care (if available at their school)
	0 to 2-year-old	NO FREE access to childcare - Note: The City provides supports to these families through Center for Families, Agenda for Children programming	

Infant / toddler | The City currently provides some high-quality supports to families with infants / toddlers

The city has several programs in place today

Childcare resources & referral	OEC’s Childcare Information Specialist provides families with information about childcare, preschool, summer programming, etc.
Center for Families (CFF)	Offers range of programming, such as Baby Univ., parent-child playgroups, mothers’ support groups, the Cambridge Dads program, case support, etc.
Agenda for Children’s Literacy	Offers programming for these families through their “Let’s Talk” initiative, which includes home visits, parent workshops, family events, and book events
Home visits	Range of programs exist in the city, including through Early Head Start and Early Intervention

With more efforts in process



Harvard Kennedy School

HKS Study

Landscape analysis of infant/toddler care in the city, focusing on the availability of high-quality, affordable care



Working group

City-wide Infant / Toddler working group to explore the circumstances and needs of 0-3 families
Recommendations to be delivered summer 2026

Infant / toddler | Even with these existing 0-3 efforts, ongoing needs for support remain, especially for lower income families

MA is the most expensive state for ITC in the country, straining many young families

ITC in the state is **3x more expensive than HHS' "affordable" level** of 7% of income

- *MA families spend an average of \$22k/year on ITC, accounting for ~20% of income*

Families **prefer childcare centers**, but cost leads many to provide **full time parental care**

- *Only 13% of Cambridge residents view full time caregiving as ideal arrangement*
- *Yet, 30% report providing full time care*

... with lower income families particularly impacted by ongoing ITC needs

Families earning <\$100k are **3x more likely** to be full time caregiver than families at \$200k+

- *45% of families earning <\$100k report providing full time parental care*

Lower income families are **substantially more likely to want "a lot more" care** than received

- *33% of lower income families report wanting "a lot more" care than currently received, compared to just 4% of higher income families*

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Potential paths | Options to expand CPP coverage for groups in need is structured around either expanding horizontal income inclusion or vertical age inclusion

Age Group	Potential path		
	① Slight horizontal increase <i>Expand priority criteria to include 65–85% or 100% AMI for 4-year-olds</i>	② Larger horizontal increase <i>Expand priority criteria to include 65–85% or 100% AMI for 3 & 4-year-olds</i>	③ Vertical increase <i>Expand services for 0 to 2-year-olds for priority families</i>
Family with 4-year-old	★ Free access to extended day / summer care	★ Free access to extended day / summer care	
Family with 3-year-old		★ Free access to preschool (school day – school year) ★ Free access to extended day / summer care	
Family with 0 to 2-year-old			★ Explore policy options to support priority families (<i>deeper dive on next slides</i>)

Peer comparison | Efforts from other cities / states to move towards a more comprehensive system of supports for families with very young children

New York City	- Like Cambridge, NYC already offers universal PK to all 4s and free preschool to many 3s - They are currently working to expand this to serve all 3s, and to expand the program to serve 2-year-olds, with the goal being to reach universal childcare 0-5 - At the same time, the city is identifying ways to facilitate the opening of new, high quality childcare centers to meet the demand
State of New Mexico	- First state in the nation to offer universal childcare, 0-5, regardless of income - Like NYC, this program also includes workforce development efforts to ensure a sufficient supply of qualified educators, and efforts to expand supply by offering low-cost loans and other supports to facilitate the opening of new childcare centers to meet demand
City of Hartford	Recently presented a proposal to provide universal childcare, focusing on 0-3 where there is the greatest need and the shortest supply

Means testing | The city has concerns with implementing means testing in CPP

While there are some potential advantages of a means-testing program ...

- ✓ **Cost savings** could be redirected to other priorities
 - ↳ *Note: cost savings limited if means-testing not applied to middle income families*
- ✓ **Preserves access** for families who might otherwise be unable to afford high-quality preschool

Note: CPP **already incorporates consideration of family income** in determining the extent of services provided to families through priority family designation

... the disadvantages threaten substantial harm to the pre-K system in the city

- ✗ Represents a **major shift** from the long-standing universal preschool commitment and messaging
- ✗ **Lose positive impacts** (learning gains, economic mobility, etc.) of universal program
- ✗ Will require **additional infrastructure & increased administrative** responsibilities to implement the sliding fee scale
- ✗ Possible negative impacts on **program diversity** from reduced enrollment

Next steps | We look forward to partnering with the Council to shape the next phase of the City's Early Childhood priorities

Key takeaways

- CPP is achieving strong outcomes: high satisfaction, high match rates, and equitable access
- These outcomes rely on significant City investment and coordinated support across providers: DHSP, CPS, and Community-Based Organizations (CBOs)
- The Council has raised four major areas for future exploration: means-testing, infant/toddler care, extended day / summer care, and expanded 3-year-old coverage
- Any CPP program changes require long lead time and would likely take effect in '28–29.

Next steps

- Discuss and finalize which potential program changes to explore further among the four options
- Provide initial directional guidance so OEC can model cost, operational, and equity implications
- Determine the desired timeline for any changes, aligned with provider-notification deadlines
- OEC will return to the Council with analysis results, alongside recommendations from the Infant/Toddler Working Group and the Harvard Kennedy School